

8.1.2 Mandriva (formerly Mandrake)

Mandriva, or Mandrake as it was earlier called, is a Red Hat derived Linux from France. It was first introduced in 1998, at a time when Linux was still associated with geekdom. Mandrake tried to fit an easy-to-use GUI to lessen the use of the command line as much as possible. Mandrake grew in popularity, and its own fan club soon followed. The latest Mandriva version is Mandriva Linux 2006, which is excellent for playing multimedia files. When we tested it, we could play almost all file types.



Mandriva 2006 incorporates KDE 3.4.2 and GNOME 2.10.2, and runs off the Kernel version 2.6.12.11. The OpenOffice.org version is the stable 1.1.5, rather than the newer pre-test 2.0 version. Application updates are very well thought out in this flavour of Linux. Mandriva now has the Smart Package Manager which can work on different types of packages, urpmi repository, rpm directory, apt-get repositories, apt-rpm repositories, Slackware repositories and deb directories.

Mandriva has been known for its centralised controlling tool called Mandriva Control Center, from which you can configure the entire system, soft installation/un-installations, bootup and startup options, and hardware configuration. Mandriva creates subdirectories in the Home directory called Documents, Download, and Pictures, where the appropriate files get saved by default. Installing Mandriva is easy. If, during the install, a CD is missing, you can simply choose not to install the applications in question, and continue with the rest of it—generally a less complicated install process.

Hardware support is also not an issue for this Red Hat derivative. Like its distant cousin Red Hat, Mandriva also has an Enterprise Edition and a free Personal Edition. Corporate Desktop, Server and Security based distributions are available for a price. Mandriva comes on five CDs or a single DVD. There is a “3 CD download edition” that is available as an ISO, and which can be